Dungeons & Gardens

The salt spray stings your faces as the longship grinds against the icy pier of Palebank Village. The groan of splintering ice mixes with the cries of gulls and the shouts of dockworkers bundled in furs. Palebank Villages greets you with a blast of frigid air, a stark contrast to the relative warmth of the southern seas you've left behind. The sky above is a perpetual grey, heavy with the promise of more snow.

You've endured weeks at sea, braving treacherous currents and icy squalls aboard the *Frostwind*, a sturdy, if somewhat cramped, longship captained by the weathered and taciturn Jarl Stonebeard. The journey itself proved more than just a test of sea legs; it was during those long, monotonous days and nights that your paths first crossed. Over shared meals of salted fish and hardtack, huddled around the meager warmth of the ship's brazier, you discovered a shared purpose beneath your disparate backgrounds. Perhaps it was a whispered conversation overheard in the galley, a chance encounter on deck under the pale moonlight, or a late-night debate in the cramped crew quarters, but you each realized you were drawn north by the same alluring whispers: the rediscovery of Aeorian ruins, remnants of a lost civilization swallowed by the Frostfell. Tales of lost cities and powerful artifacts have spread like wildfire, carried on the winds and traded in taverns from the Menagerie Coast to the shores of Wildemount. These stories have lured explorers, scholars, and fortune-seekers alike to this desolate land, and fate, or perhaps something more, has brought you together on this shared voyage.

Palebank Village, a ramshackle collection of wooden buildings huddled against the harsh landscape, serves as the primary gateway to the frozen Island of Eiselcross to the North. Here, amidst the bustle of fur traders, fisherfolk, grizzled explorers, shady mercenaries and hopeful fortune-seekers, you disembark. The air is thick with anticipation, a palpable sense of excitement mixed with a healthy dose of apprehension. The promise of uncovering lost knowledge, powerful magic, and perhaps even unimaginable wealth hangs heavy in the air, a beacon in this frozen wilderness. But the frozen shores of Eiselcross hold many secrets, and the ruins of Aeor are guarded by more than just ice and snow. Ancient dangers stir beneath the frozen surface, and the secrets you seek may come at a terrible price. Your journey into the heart of Eiselcross begins now, the moment your boots touch the frozen ground.

Welcome to Palebank Village

In the frosty expanse of the colder reaches of Wildemount, in the Greying Wildlands south of the Islands of Eiselcross, lay the haphazard cluster known as Palebank Village. It was a place more cobbled together than planned, with just over a hundred cabins and shacks pressed against the northern cliffs that rose a mere fifteen feet against the lapping rhythms of the icy harbor waves. The docks, busy with the absence of departing ships, whispered tales of neglect and wariness.

On this frigid day, the village was subdued, gathered in mournful procession for the unfortunate Urgon, a dwarven adventurer whose final journey was to the graveyard west of the harbor. There, encased in a casket more suitable for a relic than a beloved friend, he lay suspended in a state of frozen eternity. Villagers whispered tales of his return from a year-long venture into Eiselcross, burdened with treasures and a chilling affliction. Despite countless efforts, Urgon could never find warmth. Eventually, blue streaks marred his pallor, snaking through his veins, until his entire being succumbed to the grip of frost.

We followed the procession, taking note of the landscape dotted with quaint inns and supply shops. Amongst the mourners stood a weathered elf adorned with the insignia of a "Glassblade". Introducing himself as Elro, he shared that the usual voyages to Aeor had ceased; a silent testament to the mystery shrouding Urgon's demise. Elro sought our help in unveiling the source of this insidious curse, admitting that Urgon's home remained unexplored.

Word reached us quickly that another villager named Tulgi was showing similar symptoms—her fate seemingly entwined with Urgon's. Fortuitously, their cabins stood in proximity.

Beer with the Locals

In the heart of the village, a jovial dwarf Bortock tended bar at the local tavern. Elara, ever inquisitive, engaged Bortock in conversation about Urgon's recent exploits. A night's rest was negotiated—two rooms for eight silver pieces—before being served beer by the bucket and a meal of squid rolls.

Bill, a stalwart Glassblade at one of the tavern tables, emphasized that due to the danger of the curse, all boats were being warned off from Palebank's docks. Meanwhile, we learned Tulgi was a solitary trapper, her life a mystery to most.

The Cabins of Urgon and Tulgi

With this knowledge, we ventured to Urgon's cabin where another Glass Blade vigilantly stood post. Halite led us inside, where chaos had left its mark. The mounted head of a snowy beast with grey horns seemed to have overseen the search. Books were strewn about, gear tossed aside as if someone had been desperately seeking something. Scarlet's keen eyes caught sight of a grappling hook, swiftly claiming it. Meanwhile, with a sharp mind for details, Halite, discovered a receipt within a book. Dated two months prior, it recorded the sale of Aeorian items at the local Pelc's Curiosities for a handsome sum of one thousand gold pieces. Among the items: a dagger, a scroll case, a jade statue, a quiver of arrows, a jasper-set silver ring, and two blue glass vials.

Our eyes traced tracks leading to Tulgi Lutan's snow-burdened cabin. The warmth of a fierce fire belied the untouched exterior and shuttered windows. Scarlet's knock brought a curt response, followed by Elara's soft

Appendix B — Dramatis Personae

1. **Bandits**: Guild members working for Hulil, they break into Pelc's Curiosities searching for clues about the curse and engage in combat with the adventurers before surrendering.
2. **Bill**: A Glassblade seated in the tavern, warning of the dangers associated with the curse impacting Urgon and Tulgi.
3. **Bortock**: A jovial dwarf who tends bar in the local tavern, interacting with the adventurers and providing them with refreshments and lodging information.
4. **Elara**: An inquisitive member of the party, likely with magical abilities, as she performs spells and aids Kragor with healing.
5. **Elro**: A weathered elf adorned with the insignia of a "Glassblade." He introduces himself to the adventurers at Urgon's funeral and seeks their help in determining the cause of the curse.
6. **Halite**: A towering goliath fighter, characterized by his immense size and strength. His weapon of choice is a massive trident, and he acts with determination and strategy during conflicts.
7. **Hulil Lutan**: Tulgi's sister, a priestess of Tiamat, and the mastermind behind the search for clues related to the freezing sickness. She has the remainder of stolen treasures at Croaker Cave.
8. **Jarl Stonebeard**: The weathered and taciturn captain of the longship *Frostwind* that brought the adventurers to Palebank Village. His demeanor is quiet, and he is experienced with sailing through icy waters.
9. **Kragor**: An orc warlock, wielding dark magic and an ethereal war hammer. He's strategically minded and capable of casting eldritch spells to protect his allies and subdue enemies.
10. **Rogue**: A thief initially grappled by Whisper on the roof. Though he seems defeated, he stealthily listens to the adventurers' plans, suggesting future intrigue.
11. **Scarlet**: A druid with access to nature magic, demonstrated by her ability to summon mist and turn her fingertips into toxic claws during combat.
12. **Tulgi Lutan**: A solitary trapper and one of the afflicted with the same symptoms as Urgon. She, along with her sister Hulil, were involved in stealing Aeorian treasures as part of a crime syndicate.
13. **Urgon**: A deceased dwarven adventurer who returned from Eiselcross with treasures and a chilling affliction. His demise is a centerpiece of the story, leading the adventurers to investigate the source of his mysterious curse.
14. **Verla Pelc**: The owner of Pelc's Curiosities, discovered frozen and lifeless in the shop by the adventurers, indicating the seriousness of the ongoing curse.
15. **Whisper**: A tabaxi with sharp senses and agility, capable of moving swiftly and silently, proving her skills when grappling with a rogue on the rooftop.

Party Inventory

Currency

Count	Coin
156	gold pieces
43	electrum pieces
249	silver pieces
415	copper pieces

Equipment

Count	Item
1	Æorian Dagger
1	Bottle of Bald Dwarf
1	Gilded Scroll Case
1	Jade Statuette of a Storm Giant
1	Silver Ring
1	Hulil's Journal
6	Arrows +1
1	grappling hook
6	crossbows
30	bolts
5	scimitars

Arrows, +1
Weapon, uncommon

You have a +1 bonus to attack and damage rolls made with this piece of magic ammunition. Once it hits a target, the ammunition is no longer magical.

Aeorian Dagger
Weapon

A finely wrought dagger previously sold to Pelc's Curiosities, pilfered by Tulgi Lutan, and surrendered by same to Kragor Grimstride.

Bald Dwarf Whisky
Consumable, uncommon

An Uthodurnian specialty spirit, with an estimated value of 25 gp.

Gilded Scroll Case
Gear

A finely crafted mahogany container adorned with gold filigree and inlaid gemstones, providing both beauty and protection for the scrolls inside. It features runes that offer magical safeguarding against damage, making it ideal for keeping valuable parchments secure.

Jade Statuette of a Storm Giant
Miscellaneous

A meticulously carved figurine, standing approximately eight inches tall, depicting a storm giant in mid-roar, with intricate details capturing the raw power and majesty of its kind. The deep green jade shimmers with veins of gold, suggesting latent magical energies, and when held during a lightning storm, the statuette seems to vibrate softly, as if resonating with the storm's fury. Ancient runes inscribed at the base suggest it could be used in rituals to commune with primal forces of nature, potentially granting temporary insight or power related to storms.

Silver Ring
Jewelry

A silver ring with an inset jasper stone.

Hulil's Journal
Book, common

Hulil Lutan's journal, mentioning that she sold a vial of blue powder to Irven Liel.

words which coaxed the door open. Tulgi's face, marked by the same blue streaks that had doomed Urgon, was a testament to her shared affliction. She admitted her illness, confessing she and her sister Hulil, newcomers from Shady Creek Run, were in league with a crime syndicate. They had been sent to pilfer Aeorian treasures. It was they who had ransacked Urgon's home, and Tulgi who now surrendered a finely wrought dagger into Kragor's keeping.

She said that her sister Hulil held the remainder of the treasures in Croaker Cave, though Tulgi hadn't seen her in weeks.

Onward

With our next destination clear, we hiked to Pelc's Curiosities. We found the shop marked by a dragon-gilded "P" where the front door sagged invitingly open, beckoning us into the next chapter of this unfolding tale.

Pelc's Curiosities

The party stands outside Pelc's Curiosities, the door slightly ajar. Suspecting intruders, Whisper closes her eyes while softly purring "Maior et Fortior". The air around her shimmers momentarily as she draws on her inner ki in concentration. She then peers into the doors and the windows of the building. Despite her efforts, she cannot make out very much, though she hears enough rustling to make her hairs bristle. It sounds as though there are several inside ransacking the place. Scarlet joins Whisper's investigation, attempting to divine whether the noises might simply be animals, yet she senses no wildlife inside.

Preparing for potential conflict, Kragor stands up straight and stretches out his arms as if to grasp a weapon. In a loud yet distant voice he exclaims "Malleum Evoco". Suddenly ethereal shadows stream in from all directions and coalesce into an obsidian black war hammer with an angular and brutal head. Its every surface is etched with subtle twisting runes. Kragor hefts the weapon with both hands, then widens his stance with feet planted firmly on the ground.

The goliath Halite likewise readies himself, his massive frame towering above even Kragor. With deliberate, practiced movements, he adjusts his gleaming bronze shield, its surface etched with intricate clan markings. In one enormous hand he carefully grips his trident, its three wickedly barbed prongs designed not just to pierce, but to tear and rend flesh. The trident promises not just death, but a savage, lingering demise.

Surprise

Inside Pelc's Curiosities lie the answers to the freezing curse. Anxious for action, Elara takes a deep breath, tapping into her well of magic. Her fingers trace the air, summoning the rhythm of a battle drum. Her magic ignites, sending an illusory racket echoing from within the shop's shadowed walls. Startled into silence, the adversaries within hold their breath, their schemes momentarily unraveled. As Whisper crouches beside her, he senses the tension mounting. Without warning, a crossbow bolt whistles past, narrowly missing him. Elara's calculated ruse works, urging their foes to react blindly. The door slams shut, a temporary barrier between them and danger.

"So much for the element of surprise," mutters Kragor.

Undeterred, Elara shoulders the door open again. Darkness seeped around her like ink in water, yet her keen eyes, accustomed to shadow, discerned the outlines of two startled bandits amid the cluttered ruins of the shop. Ancient relics lay strewn about like casualties of an invisible war; toppled bookshelves and shattered relics spoke of a hasty, chaotic search.

The bandits, their nerves frayed by Elara's eerie magic, released their crossbow bolts in a jittery frenzy. The bolts missed their marks, striking harmlessly against worn brick and aged wood. Assessing the chaotic tableau before her, Elara hesitated; caution whispered in her ear, suggesting a withdrawal from direct assault into strategic retreat.

Inspiration and Fog

She retreated to her waiting comrades, her mind spinning a fresh tapestry of strategy. Checking again her surroundings, Kragor meets her gaze with a blend of curiosity and gruff admiration. Her eyes locked with his, and in that silent exchange, understanding was born. Elara struck her hand drum, each beat a pulse of power transmitted through the air, wrapping around Kragor like a cloak of inspiration. The rhythmic symphony reignited his focus, sharpening his spirit for the clash ahead.

massive Tiamat tapestry looms overhead, its multi-headed dragon seeming to watch their every move.

A quick search of the bodies yields eight gold pieces and five silver pieces, but no keys.

Doctor Pepe approaches the chest, his rogue's eye immediately drawn to its unusual lock. Shaped like a dragon's head, the lock bristles with intrigue. Small pin holes pepper its surface, each filled with a fine blue powder. "Interesting," he mutters, carefully examining the mechanism.

Using a leather pouch to protect his hand, he begins to extract the blue powder. It's abundant, but his practiced fingers manage to contain most of it within the pouch.

Scarlet steps forward to examine the chest. She closes her eyes and murmurs, "Revela nocuit et morbus." As the words weave through the air, a soft luminous aura emanates from her hands, casting an ethereal glow.

"There's magical contagion in the pouch," she warns. "And in the chest itself." She pauses, her gaze shifting. "Oh, and Old Croaker? Definitely venomous."

Working together with Elara, Doctor Pepe carefully picks the lock. The chest opens with a soft click, revealing its treasures: a gilded scroll case, a jade statuette of a storm giant, a quiver with six clearly magical arrows, a silver ring set with a jasper stone, 800–900 coins, and an old notebook.

"These," Doctor Pepe says, "match the items on Urgon's receipt. Except the two blue vials are missing."

Doctor Pepe beckons the others closer. With meticulous care, he removes the chest's contents, ensuring no blue powder is disturbed. He begins to count the coins, his fingers moving methodically. "Let's see," he mutters. "415 copper pieces, 234 silver pieces, 43 electrum pieces, and 112 gold pieces."

Halite takes the notebook, his massive hands carefully turning the pages. His eyes narrow as he reads Hulil's journal. "This is interesting," he says. "Hulil was trying to collect funds to purchase a cure for her disease. She sold one of the blue vials to someone named Irven Liel."

The party exchanges knowing glances, the weight of their discovery hanging in the air like a promise of deeper mysteries yet to be unraveled.

With nothing more to explore, and exhausted from the morning's events, they decide to leave. They coax Old Croaker once more with bat treats, using the massive frog to ferry them back across the underground pool. Retracing their steps, they exit the cavern.

As they step outside, they find the sun high in the sky, its warm light a stark contrast to the damp, dark world they've just left behind.

Whisper looks back at the cave entrance. "Fucking frog," she mutters under her breath.

yet, fortified by sheer willpower, she resists the full force of the arcane assault.

With a gesture imbued with ancient malevolence, Kragor again unleashes his eldritch blast, a tendril of otherworldly light that tears through the fabric of reality, wrapped in the chill embrace of necrotic energies. This time the blast impacts Hulil, and it seethes with the whispers of forgotten realms, unraveling her very essence beneath a suffocating miasma of decay. The force spreads like a dark plague, methodically consuming vitality and sowing despair in its wake, leaving naught but a hollow echo of cosmic dread.

Allowing no time for Hulil to recover, Scarlet channels natural energy through her quarterstaff, its wood shimmering with an ethereal glow. As the staff connects with the Hulil's jaw, Scarlet's druidic power amplifies the force of the strike, delivering a bone-jarring impact that crackles with mystical energy.

Hulil staggers to her feet, fury and agony blazing in her eyes like twin infernos. Doctor Pepe, with ice-cold precision, discharges another bolt, tearing into the dwarf priestess's abdomen.

Nearby, Halite hears a splash behind him but remains steadfast. With a swift motion, he plunges his javelin into Hulil's heart. Her eyes wide, the fire within them slowly extinguishing as she collapses, she rasps a final curse: "May you be consumed by endless desire… let your victories sow only tyranny and ruin… may all… you covet… turn to ash in your grasp."

Beast gonna feast

Meanwhile, hearing the sounds of battle echoing across the cavern, Whisper knocks out the bound dwarf. Determined to join the fray, she attempts to scamper across the cave wall. Instead, she slips and falls with a splash into the water.

Old Croaker startles at the sudden disturbance. The massive frog's head snaps toward Whisper, jaws wide, but miraculously misses. Whisper swims away from the predatory amphibian and begins climbing the wall again.

Old Croaker leaps at Whisper but cannot quite reach her, its massive form creating waves in the underground pool.

Elara attempts to calm the massive frog. "O magnificent amphibian, if you take us back across," she offers, "we'll give you more food." But Old Croaker has other ideas. "Kitten sandwich," the frog seems to communicate, eyeing Whisper with hungry intent.

Kragor hexes the frog and attempts to blast it with eldritch energy. "Damn it!" he curses as the blast goes wide.

Doctor Pepe also shoots wildly into the darkness, his bolt disappearing without effect.

"Who needs enemies with friends like these," Elara sighs.

Whisper manages to scramble away into the main cavern, and drops to the floor. "Fucking frog!" she mutters.

Halite surveys the aftermath of battle, a grim idea forming. With raw, brutal strength, he reaches down to the fallen elf and— with a sickening tear— removes a hand from the corpse. He tosses it to Elara, who catches it with a mixture of horror and fascination.

Old Croaker lurches toward Elara, its massive form seeking a meal. The frog's jaws snap, but miraculously miss her. Elara, her stomach turning, holds out the elf's hand. The massive amphibian sits back, mouth opening like an oversized baby bird expecting a treat.

"Lovely," she mutters. She tosses the hand into the frog's waiting maw. Old Croaker catches it with frightening efficiency, then silently slips back into the pool, leaving nothing but ripples in its wake.

What lies within

The party scans the room. Beyond the bodies and the imposing altar, a single chest sits conspicuously against the cavern wall. The

But as this is happening, Scarlet quickly reacts. "Voco Nubes!" she bellows while raising her gnarled staff to the sky. Her eyes close in concentration as she summons nature's veil. Wisps of mist curl around her fingers before surging toward the building. The vapor seeps through cracks and under doorways, expanding rapidly into a dense, swirling fog that blankets the room. The once-clear space becomes an opaque, ethereal haze, obscuring vision and muffling sound. The druid smiles, knowing the shrouded interior will confound any occupants, granting her allies the advantage they seek within the murky cover of the fog cloud. She wastes no time taking advantage of it herself: she sneaks into the building and hugs the wall, moving to the right. She can hear others moving inside as well, but can make out nothing through the fog.

First Blood

Watching one of his allies attacked and another diving into the fog and what must certainly be mortal danger, Kragor strains to think. He feels like a sitting duck outside with obscured enemies inside, ready to make a pincushion out of him with their crossbow bolts. Taking a deep breath to overcome his fear, he too rushes through the doorway into the shrouding fog, gripping his massive conjured war hammer tightly. Unable to see, he positions himself protectively before where he believes Scarlet to be, straining to detect any threats hidden in the mist. A sudden noise to his left spurs him into action. He swings wildly, the war hammer arcing through the air, and feels a heavy impact followed by a muffled crunch. The enemy's body collapses to the ground with a lifeless thud.

The Roof

Outside, Whisper's sharp tabaxi senses are attuned to every movement around her. As her gaze sweeps upward, it catches upon an unexpected anomaly: a crouched form perched on the rooftop. Though the figure's features are obscured by distance, their posture is a tapestry of uncertainty, a riddle waiting to be unraveled. Without hesitation, Whisper draws upon her innate agility, launching herself up the building's facade, her movements a dance of precision and power. Within moments, she alights upon the roof beside the puzzled figure. As she closes in, a momentary clumsiness intrudes upon her fluid motion; her limbs entangle with the figure in a grapple that is awkward but surprisingly effective. Despite the ungraceful tangle of arms and legs, her determination holds fast, securing her quarry beneath the vast blue sky. The figure, now clearly a rogue based on their dark attire and tools of the trade hanging from their belt, desperately attempts to free themselves from Whisper's grasp, to no effect.

Counterattack

Halite now grasps the perilous choice the party has made in their recklessness. With a fierce resolve etched in the hard lines of his goliath visage, he charges through the fog-choked doorway, instinctively veering left to secure the flank opposite Scarlet and Kragor. The mist clings to him, a shroud of uncertainty, yet he moves with the confidence of one accustomed to the unseen. A bandit lunges at him, the attack a mere whisper of danger that dissolves into emptiness. Seizing the opportunity, Halite's fingers tighten around his trident, that harbinger of despair. With an expert thrust, the weapon slices through the fog, hungry for blood. It strikes true, embedding itself deep within the bandit with a sickening resistance, as though the weapon savored its work. Halite has to struggle to wrench it free from the bandit with raw power, the action accompanied by a dreadful noise that the fog quickly absorbs.

While recovering his favored weapon, Halite hears the "whoosh" of a crossbow bolt. He flinches, but he is not the target. He hears Kragor cry out in desperate pain.

The bolt had struck Kragor just below the collarbone, close to his heart. Blood flows unchecked, staining his leather armor.

Seconds later, another bolt pierces Scarlet and a sharp pain flares beneath her ribs. Blood seeps into her cloak, mingling with the forest's earthy scent.

Rogue Fall

Whisper, poised at the edge of the rooftop's precipice, maintains a firm hold on the rogue. Despite the rogue's cunning and agility, he struggles to free an arm to launch a counterattack with his dagger. Nevertheless, Whisper's sharp claws and expert grip keep him securely restrained. Beneath her, the store's chaos swirls, a symphony of survival and sorcery; each cry, each clash a note struck sharp in the chord of battle below. Her decision solidifies with the clarity of ice forming, abandoning subtlety for swiftness. With a sudden, fluid ferocity, she thrusts the entangled rogue from the roof, the figure plummeting and landing with a sickening thud upon the hard earth. The world contracts around her as she vaults down, feline grace reclaiming momentum in mid-air, her heart a steady drumbeat beneath her silken fur. She lands silently, flowing through the doorway like a stream of midnight water into the tempest of friend and foe, ready once more to thread her prowess into the weaving of combat's fierce tapestry. The thrown rogue, battered and broken, lies forgotten amidst the rubble.

Elara is startled by Whisper's sudden reappearance. Despite this, she remains focused on the building, her senses registering enough to grasp that her companions are in grave danger. She urgently calls out to Scarlet, telling her to dispel the fog cloud, which Scarlet promptly does. Without hesitation, Elara rushes to join her and Kragor inside. Whisper follows but pauses in the doorway, alert for threats inside or out.

Medic!

Surveying Scarlet and Kragor's injuries, she quickly assesses that Kragor's condition is more critical. She places her hands gently on the grievous puncture wound left by the crossbow bolt, her touch glowing with divine energy. The healing light rapidly closes the wound, restoring vitality to his mottled green-gray skin. Kragor, caught off guard yet deeply appreciative, meets Elara's kind gaze, and a silent bond is forged between the orc and the aasimar.

Final Blows

As Elara is tending to Kragor, Scarlet runs towards a nearby bandit that is just now orienting themselves after the fog dispersed. Eyes glowing with untamed magic, Scarlet calls upon nature's wrath. With a fierce, primal incantation, her fingertips elongate into razor-sharp claws, dripping with corrosive acid. In a swift motion, she lashes out, and her savage strike lands true. The bandit staggers back, pain etched across their face as the toxic claws rend through leather and flesh, leaving a searing wound. The druid's usually gentle demeanor is momentarily overshadowed by raw, feral power, as the bandit teeters on the brink of defeat, humbled by nature's unforgiving might.

Halite steps forward with a grim determination, his massive form casting a foreboding shadow over the bandit struggling to stay upright from Scarlet's fierce attack. With a swift and fluid motion defying his immense size, Halite shifts his weight back, then lunges forward with an uppercut trajectory. It pierces through the air with a whistling sound, meeting the bandit's chest in a visceral collision. The force of the jab lifts the bandit off his feet momentarily, his final gasp cut short by the weapon's deadly embrace. Life flickers out of his eyes, and the limp body slides down the trident's length. Halite grimaces, more out of reflex than malice, as he shakes the bandit free with a swift, practiced motion, the lifeless form dropping to the ground with a thud.

Now sufficiently recovered to rejoin the battle, Kragor focuses his attention on the bandit far across the room that he suspects of shooting him. Although he can't be sure of the bandit's guilt, he raises his war hammer toward his

transforming into something almost docile. "We need to cross," she tells it softly. Old Croaker, understanding, moves to the pool's edge.

"Well," Elara says, stepping forward with a mixture of excitement and trepidation, "I'll go first." She carefully climbs onto the frog's broad back, her movements careful but confident. Old Croaker begins to swim across the underground pool, Elara perched atop it like an unlikely queen of this subterranean realm.

Tiamat's priestess

Elara clings to Old Croaker's back as they glide across the underground pool. Dismounting with practiced grace, her sharp eyes survey the cavern. An enormous fire illuminates a scene of unsettling drama—shadows dance across stone, cast by two robed figures kneeling before a tapestry depicting a fearsome multi-headed dragon.

The robes of the dwarf woman and the male elf match the tapestry's hues. The dwarf's blued skin betrays the creeping freezing disease.

Pressing against the cavern wall, Elara watches as Old Croaker swims back for her companions: Halite, Doctor Pepe, Kragor, and Scarlet. Whisper stays behind, guarding their captured dwarf informant.

When the party finally joins Elara on the far shore, Scarlet studies the tapestry with a scholar's precision. "Tiamat," she murmurs, more to herself than to her companions. "The scaled tyrant. Embodiment of greed. One of the betrayer gods, sworn enemy of Bahamut, the Platinum Dragon."

"A betrayer god?!," exclaims Elara.

Startled, the robed figures turn. Their fire-cast shadows loom monstrously. The dwarf is unmistakably Hulil Lutan, Tiamat's priestess.

"Halt!" Hulil barks, her voice crackling with authority. Her diseased skin gleams with those telltale blue streaks. "Who dares approach our sacred space? Drop your weapons and explain yourselves!"

Elara steps forward, her diplomatic mask sliding into place. "We are sent by the dragons," she says smoothly, "to understand the origin of this disease."

Elara's deception falls flat, and Hulil lets out a sharp, mirthless laugh. "Lies! You're nothing but intruders!"

Kragor responds, a sickening glow crackling as he hexes the elf. From his outstretched hand a purple shock of darkness blasts forward but misses and strikes stone harmlessly.

Scarlet charges, swinging her quarterstaff fueled by druidic power, but misses the elf by inches. On the other hand, Doctor Pepe's crossbow bolt finds the elf's neck, silencing him forever.

Halite throws his javelin with horrifying force and it pierces Hulil's hip, pain twisting her features. "Flee!" she commands in response, magical compulsion threading her words. But Halite's will remains unbroken.

A spectral sword materializes, its pommel shaped like a dragon's claw. It swings at Halite, missing him by a hairsbreadth.

Elara's shortbow sings, her arrow finding Hulil's shoulder. The dwarf winces but remains standing.

Kragor now turns his hex on Hulil, firing another eldritch blast that goes wildly off-target.

Doctor Pepe's next shot is solid, sinking deep into Hulil's shoulder and driving her back momentarily.

Hulil's hand summons a sickly green, jagged blade. She swings it at Halite, but his armor deflects the strike. Then, with practiced motion, she pulls out a potion and drinks. Instantly, her wounds begin to heal.

In the dimly lit cavern, Elara's fingers dance over her shimmering harp. Hulil pauses as the chilling notes paint vivid fears across her mind,

The dwarf nods toward the sleeping quarters. "A pit, covered by a bedroll."

Halite growls, "You'll live. For now." The dwarf's resigned eyes hint at fear of what's to come.

Doctor Pepe notices a bucket… on closer examination, it is full of dead bats. "Interesting. These bats could distract the frogs— a tactical edge."

Doctor Pepe binds the dwarf with rope from his pack. Halite stands guard, an imposing sentinel.

The others turn their attention to the grim task of searching their fallen adversaries. Kragor retrieves a crossbow. "Still serviceable," he notes.

Scarlet counts out coins from a waterlogged purse. "Seven gold, ten silver," she reports, the metal catching the dim light with a dull gleam. "Not exactly a king's ransom."

Dungeon crawl

In the cave, the prisoner shuffles under Halite's stern watch, boots scraping the stone floor. They reach a makeshift camp, a fire pit in the center. Whisper conjures a flame with a soft "Lux naturae," illuminating the scene.

Doctor Pepe's keen eyes catch a bedroll lying suspiciously flat. "It's the pit trap of which the dwarf spoke," he warns, pointing to the hidden danger.

Scarlet uncovers an unopened bottle amongst the camp supplies. "Bald Dwarf whiskey," she notes, smirking. "Made by elves."

"Elves making dwarf whiskey? A fine tale," Kragor chuckles.

"Nice. That might fetch as much as 25 gold pieces," Doctor Pepe notes, his rogue's mind already calculating potential value.

The party's attention shifts to two corridors leading away from the campsite. Halite suggests exploring one, with Doctor Pepe following. The corridor gradually widens, opening into a larger cavern. As their eyes adjust to the dim light, they realize they are surrounded by hanging bats.

Suddenly, the bats stir. Their collective movement creates a rustle of wings that fills the cavern with an ominous sound. Halite, startled, begins stabbing wildly with his trident. The weapon misses the bats entirely, instead striking a nearby stalagmite with a sharp crack.

"We need to go!" Doctor Pepe insists.

The two of them retreat, joining the others who are exploring the second corridor. "Bats," Halite explains simply.

Old Croaker

Kragor is the first to notice the expansive underground pool, its dark waters stretching beyond the reach of their light. The cavern seems to breathe with subterranean stillness, broken only by the occasional drip of water from unseen stalactites.

"What's across there?" Kragor demands, turning to the wounded dwarf. "How do we get over?"

The dwarf's eyes dart nervously across the water. "Well," he says, his voice trembling slightly, "Old Croaker ferries people across."

Before anyone can ask who or what Old Croaker is, a massive shape begins to emerge from the murky depths. Even among giant frogs, this creature is truly enormous— easily the size of a small boat, its skin a mottled green and blue, eyes like dark pools of ancient malevolence.

Scarlet steps forward, her movements calm and deliberate. In her hand, she holds one of the dead bats from their earlier discovery. "Easy now," she murmurs, her voice a soothing melody of nature's own language.

With extraordinary skill, Scarlet reaches out with her hand, gently stroking its massive head. To everyone's amazement, the creature seems to relax under her touch, its previous menace

target and shouts, "Te Exsecro!" The air shimmers with malevolent energy as a cold, dark aura coils around the bandit like an invisible serpent. Without hesitation, Kragor follows with another spell, yelling "Dolor," and unleashes a surge of eldritch energy from his war hammer that strikes the bandit square in the chest. The impact of the blast results in an ugly wound. Immediately, shadowy tendrils twist and curl over the shredded flesh causing it to blacken and crumble, leaving the bandit teetering on the brink of death.

Surrender

Halite, his towering form casting an imposing shadow across the cluttered interior of the ransacked antique shop, moved with purpose toward Kragor's target: a bandit whose bravado had been seared away by the crackling energy of the orc warlock's magic. The air still shimmered with the fading traces of arcane power, and the bandit, already on the brink of collapse, could only watch as the goliath fighter closed the distance between them like an inexorable force of nature.

The trident in Halite's grip gleamed with an unsettling menace, its barbed points promising a swift and painful end should it be called upon to deliver one. The bandit, a mere lithe elf in the presence of such formidable warriors, felt the weight of his own mortality for what seemed like the first time. His sword clattered to the wooden floor, a hollow sound that resonated through the shop, punctuating his surrender.

"I yield," the bandit croaked, his voice strained with fear and desperation. He raised his hands, palms open and empty, a universal sign of capitulation. His eyes darted to his remaining comrade, wide with silent urging.

The last standing bandit, who had watched the battle unfold with growing dread, knew the odds all too well. He had witnessed the fate of their fallen companions—three already dispatched with ruthless efficiency by the duo of Kragor and Halite. The decision was not a difficult one.

He dropped his own weapon, a well-worn crossbow, to the floor and raised his hands above his head in submission. "We don't want anymore trouble," he said, his voice carrying a tremor that matched the frantic beating of his heart.

Kragor surveyed the scene, his eyes, glowing faintly with residual magical energy, meeting Halite's. An unspoken understanding passed between them—this victory, as hard-fought as it was, did not need to claim further lives.

With the tension of combat beginning to ebb, the antique shop's air felt still, though the echoes of the skirmish lingered. Surrounded by overturned furniture and scattered relics of a bygone era, the bandits' surrender marked the end of the struggle, their lives spared by the mercy of those far mightier than they.

Whisper, having ensured the rogue she tossed from the roof was no longer a threat, finally entered the antique shop and closed the door behind her. As she did, the rogue moved to a crouched position around the corner, relieved that his theatrics had been successful. Intending to enter the building when the coast was truly clear, he remained vigilant, pressing his ear to the cool glass of the window to eavesdrop on the victorious adventurers.

Interrogation

Elara and Scarlet eyed the bandits with intensity, their curiosity piqued by the confession of surrender. "Who are you and what were you doing here?" Elara demanded, her voice steady yet demanding answers.

The first bandit, regaining a bit of composure but still visibly shaken, replied, "We were sent by Hulil, a priestess of Tiamat. She instructed us to search this place. Two months ago, there was a robbery here, and now Hulil's got this strange freezing sickness. She hoped we might find a clue here in the shop. But we found nothing."

Scarlet's gaze remained firm as she pressed

further, “Then why did you attack us?”

A hint of embarrassment colored the bandit’s cheeks. “We were spooked. We heard some weird noise, then you guys barged in. Especially that chick with a horn on her head,” he gestured toward Elara. “We panicked. We’re not used to dealing with people like you.”

In the meantime, the rogue outside, crouching below the window, absorbed the exchange, piecing together the dynamics at play.

Scarlet produced a weathered receipt with notations about Aeorian artifacts and presented it to the bandits. “Have you seen these items?”

“They’re with Hulil,” the bandit admitted reluctantly, his eyes on the documentation with evident recognition. “She’s at Croaker’s Cave,” confirming what the party had already learned from Hulil’s sister, Tulgi.

Satisfied with the information, Kragor dismissed the subdued bandits in no uncertain terms: “Leave everything and get out.” Seizing their chance, the bandits quickly discarded their weapons and coins before hurrying for the door, the rogue outside remaining concealed until the coast was truly clear.

Loot

After searching the bandits’ leavings and their late compatriots’ bodies, the party tallied the loot: 14 gold pieces, eight silver pieces, five crossbows, 30 bolts, five scimitars, and a dwarf-sized shirt blazoned with “Scanlan Shorthalt — The Meat Man Cometh”. (Elara judged this last item to be a rare find and might fetch as much as two gold pieces.)

The party then turned to the antique shop, assessing the chaos that engulfed it. The room was in disarray, bookshelves overturned and trinkets strewn about. Amidst the disorder, they stumbled upon a chilling sight—a frozen elf lying lifeless in bed. It was Verla Pelc, and the grim discovery confirmed that the place had not seen tidiness for weeks.

In a thorough inspection of both the shop and the dead bandits’ belongings, they discovered two bows and various odds and ends. Deciding a respite was in order, they planned to rest before heading to Croaker Cave.

Who is this guy?

Unbeknownst to the adventurers, the rogue remained vigilant, listening to their intentions and preparing to bide his time until they left.

takes aim at Elara, embedding a bolt into her thigh. She gasps, momentarily swaying, her focus clouded by the sting.

Retreating further into the cave’s depths, the dwarf’s footsteps echo and fade, leaving only the rhythmic drip of water and the murmur of unseen currents.

Crossing the pool

Faced with the challenge of pursuing a dwarf across a frigid pool, the party assesses their options. The wooden beam that seems to have been used by the bandits sits tantalizingly across the water.

Scarlet throws her grappling hook, but it misses the beam, snagging something underwater instead. As she pulls, Halite steps in to help. Together, they haul up a mass: a dead bandit and a distressed, living frog!

Kragor, sensing danger, hexes the frog and targets it with an eldritch blast. The frog disintegrates under the force of the blast.

Elara, steadying herself, heals her thigh wound with divine magic. Scarlet mirrors her, healing Doctor Pepe with nature’s energies.

Their reprieve is brief. The dwarf reappears, firing a bolt that bounces off Halite’s armor. “Damn it,” Doctor Pepe grumbles, frustration etched into his features. “We need to see!” He hurls his enchanted dagger, which thuds into the beam, revealing the far shore with its glow.

Driven by urgency, Whisper leaps onto the wall, climbing swiftly and landing silently on the far side, her eyes finding the dwarf hidden in shadows.

With a flick of his wrist, Halite throws the grappling hook, this time securing the beam. He pulls it towards him until it rests securely across the pool, then charges confidently across, joining Whisper. Kragor and the rest of the party follow, anticipation fueling each stride.

Scarlet conjures a flame to illuminate their path. Doctor Pepe retrieves his glowing dagger, its light warding off the gloom, as he brings up the rear.

Seeing them approach, the dwarf panics, firing wildly. The bolt clatters harmlessly off stone.

Interrogation in the Depths

In the dim cave light, Whisper, poised and predatory, lunges at the dwarf, her speed a shadowy blur. Yet the dwarf’s shield deflects her strike with a resonant thud that shakes the cavern. Halite follows swiftly, his javelin piercing the dwarf with deadly precision, bringing him to his knees.

Elara arrives, agile and commanding, her voice sharp with authority. “Tell us the secrets of this place.”

Despite his pain, the dwarf’s eyes remain dull and silent. Kragor steps forward, his voice echoing with Elara’s urgency. “When a lady speaks, you damn well better listen.”

“What family are you with?” Halite’s voice booms.

“The Uttolot family,” the dwarf finally admits, defiance lacing his words.

Halite’s massive frame looms over him. “And what are you doing in this cave?”

The dwarf swallows hard. “We… we feed the frogs,” the dwarf confesses. “I work here. For Hulil. Train them to carry us. They used to eat more— whatever Hulil wanted.”

Scarlet’s eyebrow arches. “More what?” The dwarf squirms. “Bats, small game, even people. Hulil trained them.”

Halite’s gaze darkens. “Tell us about Hulil.” The dwarf blanches. “She’s sick. Sent several of us to town for a clue to the disease— but none returned. She plans to sell Tulgi’s loot in Shadycreek Run. Hoping for a cure.”

Whisper leans in. “Are there traps here? Tell us what you know.”

pool erupts, and two mastiff-sized blue frogs emerge, their slick bodies glinting ominously.

One frog leaps at Doctor Pepe, its jaw snapping with ferocious hunger. His reflexes, sharp from experience, save him; he sidesteps as its maw closes on empty air. But the second frog's attention locks onto Whisper. With a sudden lurch, it fastens its jaws around her, seriously wounding her. Its coarse tongue feels rough against her fur as it pins her with a vice-like grip. Whisper's world constricts around the raw strength of the creature, her body momentarily immobilized by the force of its bite.

Her once luxurious fur matted with blood and frost, her breath shallow and labored, Whisper summons her inner strength to claw free, leaving shallow crimson trails across the frog's blue skin in retaliation.

Outside, Elara leads the party at the cave entrance. "They're in trouble," she asserts, urgency lacing her voice. "We need to move!"

Within, the rhythmic echo of boots suggests more danger is approaching, but out of necessity, Doctor Pepe and Whisper remain focused on the immediate threat. Doctor Pepe turns his attention to the wounded frog. His shortsword pierces its slick flesh, and his dagger follows, sinking deep into its massive head. The creature shudders, momentarily stunned.

Recovering quickly, the frog snaps at Doctor Pepe, its powerful jaws gripping him tightly. He grunts in pain, fighting against its hold.

Meanwhile, the first frog retreats toward the water, and Whisper's retaliatory strike misses. Frustrated yet determined, she attempts to help Doctor Pepe, her claws slashing his assailant and drawing blood. Realizing she can't endure another attack, she makes a calculated retreat, slipping gracefully back to the cave's entrance, trusting that Doctor Pepe can handle the encroaching threat momentarily.

Reinforcements

As Whisper emerges from the cave, Halite quickly gauges the peril, his resolve igniting. With swift strides, he charges inside, his trident a formidable comfort.

He finds Doctor Pepe still struggling against the frog's relentless grip. Halite drives his trident into the creature's side, but its hold does not falter. Observing the struggle, Elara weaves a melody with her harp, instilling Pepe with courage. "Remember your agility and cunning!" she calls, the sound of her voice and the vibrations of her harp soothing. She then summons the power of the stars, launching a mote of radiant energy with precision. The frog releases a guttural croak, convulsing under the assault before it releases Doctor Pepe and collapses lifelessly into the pool.

Grateful and relieved, Doctor Pepe quickly regains his composure. Meanwhile, Kragor taps into his ancestral power, muscles tensing with readiness. Yet danger lurks in the shadows. Suddenly, a crossbow bolt strikes Doctor Pepe, drawing a pained cry. Another bolt narrowly misses Halite, while a third strikes him, but only bruises his resilient skin.

Halite spots the assailants: a dwarf and two elves across the pool, crossbows poised. Outside, Scarlet rushes to Whisper's aid, healing her with soothing energy. Renewed, Whisper re-enters the cave, her sling delivering a precise blow to one of the elves before she again retreats gracefully.

Inside, Doctor Pepe, undeterred by pain, fires back with his crossbow but misses. Halite steps forward, throwing a javelin that fells the injured elf with precision. Elara, considering but deciding against leaping across the pool, channels more divine energy, striking the second elf squarely. Kragor whispers a curse, dark power seeping from his words, then unleashes tendrils of energy that knock the elf into the pool's depths.

Frustrated and fearful, the remaining dwarf curses, raising his crossbow in desperation. He

Secrets of Croaker Cave

The party retraces their steps to the *Jolly Dwarf*, where warmth greets them like an old friend. As the tavern's door swings open, hearth light flickers along the walls, merging with murmurs and the clinking of mugs. After a day of skirmishes, they retire to modest rooms, voices still echoing with plans.

Morning in Palebank Village dawns with a crisp, biting air. Frost clings to windows, and the adventurers rise at half-past seven. Below, a kettle hisses, and the aroma of breakfast fills the inn. Unusually quiet due to the port's closure, the inn has only one family— a weary pair of men with twin tiefling girls— depart, the door framing their retreat in the morning light.

Bortock, the innkeeper, greets them cheerily. "Elro was around last night, looking for you lot," he says, "He'll be back soon for news."

As Halite asks about Croaker Cave, Bortock's expression shifts subtly to one of caution. "Croaker Cave, you say? They call it that for good reason— the croaks of giant ice frogs echo from there, a sound that'd chill your bones if the cold hadn't already. None of the village folk dare set foot inside. They know where to find it, sure, but it's an unspoken rule here: no one goes into that cave."

Taking a seat, the party enjoys breakfast— warm bread, stew, and fish; a bargain at only five silver pieces— while Kragor inquires about Hulil, Tulgi's sister. Bortock scratches his beard thoughtfully, his eyes narrowing as he sifts through what bits of information he possesses. "Ah, Tulgi," he begins slowly, weighing his words. "Can't say I knew she has a sister. These folks from Shadycreek Run— always a tangled web with them. Their kin aren't exactly welcome in Palebank. Suspicion tends to follow their kind."

Ever the pragmatic, Kragor poses another question: "What about healing potions? Do you know where we might procure some?"

Bortock advises, "Try the docks. There's an old elf woman, Gramini, she sells them. Pricey, but worth it."

As breakfast concludes, Elro joins them, concern in his eyes. Scarlet updates him on their findings: connections between Tulgi, Hulil, and the village's affliction, and the tragic fate of Verla from Pelc's Curiosities. Elro nods, confirming suspicions about the Shadycreek Run families. News of dispatched bandits lightens his demeanor. "Less to worry about," he says, intending to send his men over to shop to clean up.

Still curious about their next venture, Whisper inquires, "What makes Croaker Cave particularly dangerous?" Elro turns towards her, his gaze steady. "It's the giant ice frogs. Those are the reason folks steer clear."

Scarlet, drawing from her vast trove of natural knowledge, leans forward. "How large are these frogs?" she asks.

"About the size of a large wolf," Elro replies, conjuring a vivid image in their minds.

Scarlet nods, familiar with their temperate climate counterparts. She addresses the party. "I recall they aren't venomous, but they can certainly swallow a person whole. Their stomach acid dissolves their prey, and while they're smarter than regular frogs, they're not what you would call cunning. I knew a teacher once who kept one as a pet."

Before departing, Elro implores, "Root out those Shadycreek folks. The village would owe you greatly."

The party, girded by Elro's trust and responsibility, reflects on the tapestry they are unraveling— a tapestry that now leads them to the hidden depths of Croaker Cave and the shadows lurking within.

Adventuring is hard, let's go shopping

Braving the biting cold, our adventurers reach the docks— a sprawling network of paths and shanties, each whispering tales of a bygone era. They navigate these lanes, finding the shack they seek: a dilapidated structure with an askew "Goods for Sale" sign dangling overhead.

Elara steps forward as the negotiator. Halite opens the door, releasing the tinny clang of a bell. Inside, flickering firelight reveals shelves groaning under the weight of indescribable trinkets. Behind the counter emerges a wizened elf whose blue scarf and loose coat defy the chill that seeps through the shack's walls. Her eyes, sharp despite her age, study the newcomers with cautious curiosity.

"Well, well, what's this? Adventurers, by the look of you." Her voice, both raspy and warm, mirrors the fire's flicker. "What brings you here? Looking for trinkets, or is it something more substantial?"

Elara approaches, broaching the need for potions. "You must be Gramini. We seek anything to combat the freezing illness cursing this village."

The woman's expression shifts, a glint of sympathy mixing with practicality. "Ah, if you mean Urgon's ailment, that mystery is beyond my humble potions. But I have supplies for those brave enough to venture to Eiselcross. Dangerous place, that is."

She presents four health potions. "Usually 60 gold apiece, but business has been slow lately. I'll sell them for 50 each."

Seeing an opening, Elara leans in. "Could you let them go for 30 each? The road ahead is perilous."

Gramini chuckles, a sound steeped in kindness and shrewdness. "Below cost, Sweetie? But you've got charm, I'll give you that. Alright, 48 each. A gesture of goodwill."

The negotiation leaves Elara hopeful. With business nearing conclusion, curiosity tickles her again. "Heard any tales or warnings of late, Gramini?"

Leaning back, the old elf sighs. "Troubling times, indeed. The port's closed— no ships. Palebank seems to hold its breath, waiting for a storm to pass." Her voice drops to a whisper, eyes locking with Elara's. "That freezing disease, eating at the core. Aeor is where its dark magic likely thrives. Everything from that land carries a cost, mark my words."

Elara then suggests, "We're short on coin… Perhaps a barter?"

Kragor, catching on, brandishes a shirt emblazoned with the name Scanlan Shorthalt. Gramini's eyes gleam with recognition. "Him! I've seen him perform." Fond remembrance softens her demeanor.

She proposes, "I'll give you 15 gold off the potions for that."

Donning the bard's shirt with delight, Gramini is transformed into a giddy teenager for a few moments. "Scanlan was so charming!" Her laughter chimes like a song, sealing the deal.

As the party exits, spirits buoyed, Gramini's unexpected joy lingers, a beacon against the looming shadows.

Doctor Pepe

As the party approaches Croaker Cave, they note smoke spiraling upward from a natural chimney, etching the sky with its ashen tendrils. Despite the spectral warning, the front opening of the cave appears unguarded.

Unbeknownst to them, the rogue that Whisper had previously encountered lies in wait, having shadowed the party from Palebank. As they draw nearer, he steps free of the forest's embrace, his presence a sudden ripple in the serene tableau.

"Hail, Friends! I mean you no harm," he calls out, raising his hands in a gesture of peace. "I have something I believe you need to know."

Scarlet and Whisper exchange glances before fixing their gazes upon the rogue. Recognition flickers in Whisper's eyes, a soft chuckle escaping her lips as she recalls their prior exchange on the rooftops of Pelc's Curiosities. Scarlet's expression is more guarded as she steps forward, her tone firm yet open. "Who are you?" she demands, her eyes narrowing with a blend of caution and curiosity. "And what do you want?"

The rogue spreads his arms in a gesture of openness. "Let me introduce myself. I am called Doctor Pepe," he announces. "I assure you, I was not a party to the bandits you encountered before. Like you, I've been drawn into the orbit of this mystery, investigating the source of this debilitating disease afflicting the village."

Kragor steps forward, his bearing equal parts caution and curiosity. "Well met, Doctor Pepe. What do you know of this cave?"

"Just before daybreak, I witnessed three cloaked figures enter the cave— a dwarf and two elves, if I'm not mistaken." Doctor Pepe's eyes, sharp and perceptive, scan the adventurers' faces, gauging their reaction. "Whatever transpires within, it may well relate to the affliction that has beset Palebank."

The party exchanges thoughtful glances. After weighing their options, the adventurers come to a shared conclusion. Offering the rouge a nod of acceptance, Kragor extends the group's unspoken consensus. "Then let us consider you an ally, Doctor Pepe. Together, we may better contend with whatever lies within the heart of Croaker Cave."

Trepidation's threshold

As the party assesses the scene at the cave entrance, Elara's sharp eyes catch sight of myriad footprints— heavy and light, large and small— tracing paths both in and out of the cavern's yawning mouth.

Gathering in a tight circle, they weigh their options and decide on a reconnaissance mission. It is swiftly determined that Doctor Pepe, with his keen investigative insights, and Whisper, with her silent grace, will venture in to scout the darkness and report back to the group.

To aid them in the shadowy depths, Elara steps forward and gently strums her harp, weaving magic through its strings. She sings, "Sol invictus," and with her melody, a spare dagger that Doctor Pepe holds aloft begins to glow. The light emanating from the blade now serves as both a beacon and a ward against the shadows lurking within the cave.

As Doctor Pepe and Whisper step cautiously into the cave, the world narrows around them to the soft glow of magical light. The air grows cooler, the dampness clinging to their skin like an insistent whisper. About ten feet in, they encounter a pool of water, its murky depths disturbed only by the occasional ripple from droplets falling from above.

Whisper, pausing to scan the area, notes that the ceiling, though ten feet high, bristles with stalactites, reducing the navigable space to eight feet. The constant drip of water echoes in the chamber, joined intermittently by the deep croaks of unseen amphibians. These sounds seem to resonate with the very bones of the cave, sending a shiver across her fur.

Doctor Pepe, moving with deliberate quiet, approaches the pool's edge to gain a better vantage. He squints across the still water, and on the far side, he discerns the tip of a wooden beam jutting slightly from the shadows. Suddenly he recalls that the three figures he saw entering the cave earlier were carrying a beam: this must be the way across.

Ambush

Whisper's usual grace falters when she hits a jagged stalagmite, unleashing a sharp hiss that pierces the cave's silence. Instantly, the murky